Heroes, wages and the economy

Hit points, hero wages, hiring and neutral heroes, succession, income, wealth bands and bankruptcy

Kingdoms Call reference sheet. Data file v2026.10.15-1202. Generated 2026-10-19 from the repository (branch at that date). Numbers are what the engine uses today, read straight from its tables; where a figure comes from the rulebook text instead, the section says so.

Kings and heroes are the realm's characters; gold is what keeps their armies. This sheet gathers the rules that sit between the skills and the armies: how a character toughens, what they cost, how they are hired and replaced, and how the treasury works.

What to look for when reviewing

- Hit points come only from fighting; the gain bands and the Orcish shift.
- Hero wage = total skill levels ÷ 4; a strong hero costs 5–6g a turn, more than most units.
- Wealth bands and the neutral guard that comes with each; the 5% cap on bonus tax.
- The starting position every realm shares.

Where this comes from

- Rulebook: Kings & Heroes, Hit points & recovery, Hiring wandering heroes, Hero wages, Death & succession, The Economy, Wealth, Neutral guards, What you start with.
- Engine: heroes/skills-and-hp.js, heroes/charms-and-neutrals.js, turn/early-winter (taxes and wages). Rulings R-015, R-016, R-027, R-047, R-050, R-076, R-086.

Hit points

Rule	What it is
Start	15 max HP; 18 for an Orcish character of an Orcish realm. No skill ever raises it.
Gains	After a fight the winner rolls and adds +1; any other character who took at least 1 damage and lived rolls too (one roll per fight). Every roll gains (R-086).
Bands	Below 40: 1–3. 40–49: 1–2. 50 and above: 1. Orcish characters of an Orcish realm: every band 5 higher. A rise heals into the new headroom.
Recovery	Wounds do not heal on their own. Rest: 30% of max, rounded up (Divine ×1.5). Potions, items, spells, Brave second wind, White 6 Mass Healing (half max for everyone in the province at turn's end). The Colossus minor title +2 on a Rest.
Death	A character at 0 HP may die; some survive wounded; the Cowardly may beg. No single blow takes more than half of max HP (R-080). A body stays where it fell (R-076) and can be looted or Resurrected (own fallen and never-sworn heroes only, R-028).
Items	Max HP items (15 of them) sit on top of the earned pool; remove the item and the bonus goes.

Wages and hiring

Total skill levels	1–4	5–8	9–12	13–16	17–20	21–24	25–28
Wage per turn	1g	2g	3g	4g	5g	6g	7g

Rule	What it is
Hero wage	Total skill levels ÷ 4, rounded up, minimum 1g; recalculated whenever a skill rises. Kings draw no wage. Psychic Blast lowering a skill lowers the wage (R-024). Some discoveries reduce wages.

Rule	What it is
Hiring a wanderer	Opening wage by alignment distance: 2g at 0–1 steps, 3g at 2–3, 4g at 4–5, refusal at 6 (Divine and Undead). Plus 1g per 4 total skill levels beyond a fresh hero's first few. Neutral realms pay at most 3g. Higher initiative wins a contested hire.
Neutral heroes grow	From the end of turn 5 every wanderer and chieftain has a 25% chance a turn of one skill point, never past level 5; sharing a province with another neutral hero, the skill learned is that hero's highest (R-027).
Other routes	Charm (Psychic) hires a wanderer free; Broker (Neutral king) hires at a distance; Resurrect raises the never-sworn. Orders for a hero not yet yours apply only if the hire lands (R-014).
Release	A hero (never the king) leading no army can be released; they wander again with their items and cannot be re-hired that turn.

Kings and succession

Rule	What it is
The king	Leads, fights, casts and gives the king-only orders (Consecrate, Call to Arms, Broker, Grand Design). Cannot be charmed. Only a king may run down a king (R-021). Starts with 4 skill points (at most 2 in one skill), the realm's race and alignment, a chosen temper, a small army and two heroes of 3 random points each.
Heir	When the king dies an heir is crowned in the wealthiest province at the start of the next turn: a green ruler whose name, temper and skill points you choose afresh (the alignment's +1 skill applies). A Divine king awaiting return is not succeeded while holy ground holds (R-009).
Extinction	A realm ends only when its king dies with no land to crown an heir in, or when it loses all land (R-061 for conceded realms).
Resurrect	Only the realm's own most recently fallen king, borne home, reclaims the throne; a rival's king never.

The economy

Band	Tax	Neutral guard	Notes
Poor	2–3	1–2 units	No land province pays less than 2 (R-015).
Prosperous	4–6	2–3 units	
Rich	7–10	3–4 units	A rich province (7+) is a Grand Heist target. Tax base can be raised to 10 by Sage 8 and Explorer 8.
Home	top of the scale	—	Starting income 10g a turn; fully explored; recruits every land unit of the race, two a season.
Sea	1 open water; 2–3 whale and shark waters; 4–6 the sea-monsters' waters	sea-beasts and their guardians	Claimable by a fleet; the one tax below 2.

Rule	What it is
Start	20 gold (R-016), 10 income, the king, two heroes, a small army; one poor and one prosperous neighbour, at least one of the king's race; a sea province beside a king with Naval; a Weak lair at home (R-018, R-057, R-071).
Income	Province tax, plus Neutral trade +20%, Bless (+60/80/100%), Consecrate (+50%), Plunder (Evil, 50% of tax on conquest), Blood Harvest (Pagan, 1g per unit destroyed), Sage 6 (+5g per discovery), discoveries, items, titles and stipends. Provinces conquered this turn pay at its end.
Bonus cap	No single source of bonus tax (one discovery, or all tax items together) pays more than 5% of the realm's base tax, rounded down, never less than 1g (R-050).
Spending	Recruiting (price), wages (price again every turn, garrison included; skeletons 1g; hero wages), hiring, Harvest the Field 2g, a Broker report 2g, Hunting Rumours 1–4g per lair, Wild Hunt one beast's price.
Settlement	Tax and wages settle together at turn's end, so a unit raised this turn is paid this turn: the first season costs double.
Bankruptcy	Units disband greenest first anywhere in the realm (random within a tier), skeletons last; then heroes desert. A ship carrying troops at sea is never disbanded while they would be stranded. The Deathless Legion Wonder exempts skeletons.
Theft	Steal takes 5% of a treasury; Grand Heist 25% (doubled at Thief 8). Sabotage removes a province's tax next turn; Earthquake this turn; Cataclysm permanently.

Gaps, questions and things to check

These are observations from reading the data files, the engine and the rulebook together. None of them is a ruling. Each is a question for Toby or a place where two sources disagree.

#	Observation
1	A hero at 24 skill levels costs 6g a turn, more than any unit; late-game courts are the biggest wage line. Say whether the ÷4 rate is the lever to pull for balance.
2	HP gains stall at 60; the Legendary benchmark is 60 HP. A hero past 60 gains 1 (2 as a winner) per fight, so the last twenty points take twenty fights.
3	The bonus-tax cap (5% of base) makes every +gold item and discovery worth at most the same amount per realm; a small realm's Ring of Wealth pays 1g. R-050 is confirmed but has an open question.
4	Neutral heroes grow to level 5 only; a wandering hero hired on turn 12 can be a 20-level hero costing 5g from the first turn. Players may need the asking price explained on the hire list (it is shown).
5	The king's 4 starting points and 2-per-skill limit are not in the rulebook text.
6	The home province pays "the top of the scale" but no figure is given; the starting income is 10, which with the home at tax 10 means neighbours pay nothing until taken. State the home tax.